

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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PUPPS Rash in Pregnancy

Pruritic Urticarial Papules and Plaques of Pregnancy — intensely itchy but benign

WHAT IS PUPPS?

PUPPS (Pruritic Urticarial Papules and Plaques of Pregnancy) is the most common pregnancy-specific rash, affecting **1 in 160–200 pregnancies**. It causes intensely itchy red bumps and hive-like plaques, usually starting in the stretch marks on the abdomen. It is **benign** — poses no risk to the baby.

WHO GETS PUPPS?

- Most common in first pregnancies (primigravidas)
- Usually appears in the 3rd trimester (35–39 weeks)
- More common with large weight gain or large babies
- Much more common in **twin pregnancies**
- More common when carrying a male fetus
- Rare in subsequent pregnancies (usually doesn't recur)

HOW PUPPS LOOKS & SPREADS

- Starts in abdominal stretch marks (striae)
- Spreads to thighs, buttocks, and arms
- Small red or skin-colored bumps (papules)
- Hive-like plaques that may merge
- Intense itching — often worst at night
- **Spare the face, hands, and feet**
- **No blistering** (distinguishes from pemphigoid)
- Umbilicus usually spared (unlike cholestasis)

PUPPS VS. ICP (CHOLESTASIS)

Feature	PUPPS	ICP
Rash visible?	Yes — bumps	No rash
Location	Belly/thighs	Palms/soles
Lab abnormalities	None	Elevated bile acids
Fetal risk?	None	Yes — elevated

SOOTHING TREATMENTS

- ✓ Cool oatmeal baths (Aveeno) **OTC**
- ✓ Sarna lotion (menthol/camphor) — cooling relief **OTC**
- ✓ Calamine lotion **OTC**
- ✓ Benadryl (diphenhydramine) at bedtime **OTC**
- ✓ Hydrocortisone 1% cream — mild topical steroid **OTC**
- ✓ Cold compresses on affected areas
- ✓ Loose, cotton, breathable clothing
- ✗ Avoid hot showers/baths — worsens itching

MEDICAL TREATMENTS

- **Prescription topical steroids** — triamcinolone, betamethasone cream **RX**
- **Oral antihistamines** — hydroxyzine **RX**
- **Short course of oral prednisone** — for severe PUPPS **RX**
- PUPPS resolves within 1–4 weeks of delivery
- Delivery is ultimately the cure
- Dermatology referral if diagnosis uncertain

⚠️ CALL YOUR DOCTOR IF

- ⚠️ New rash or itching that starts in the 3rd trimester
- ⚠️ Itching on palms/soles without a visible rash (rule out ICP)
- ⚠️ Itching so severe you cannot sleep for multiple nights
- ⚠️ No improvement with OTC treatments after 48–72 hours
- ⚠️ Blisters or vesicles appear (may indicate pemphigoid)
- ⚠️ Rash spreads to face or becomes infected
- ⚠️ Fever accompanying the rash
- ⚠️ Dark urine or jaundice — could indicate cholestasis

♥️ PUPPS Is Miserable, But Harmless to Your Baby

We know PUPPS itching can be truly overwhelming — it is one of the most uncomfortable pregnancy conditions. The good news: your baby is completely unaffected. With the right treatments to manage the itch, most women get through it. Delivery brings complete resolution, usually within a week or two.